

MISSION REBUILD™

MISSION REBUILD™ — Instructor Guide

*From Army to Civilian: Building Structure, Purpose,
Identity & Financial Stability After Service*

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Course: MISSION REBUILD™: From Army to Civilian

Format: 12-Week Intensive | Live Cohort + Self-Paced Option

Audience: Military veterans in transition (primary: post-ETS within 0–5 years)

Instructor Role: Peer, Guide, Experienced Operator

A note before you start: This guide is written for instructors who have lived something. You are not expected to be a licensed therapist, a corporate trainer, or a motivational speaker. You are expected to show up as someone who has been through it — and figured some things out — and who genuinely gives a damn about helping other veterans do the same. That's the job. Everything else in this guide supports that.

SECTION 1: COURSE PHILOSOPHY

What This Course Is NOT

Be clear on this with yourself before you ever open your mouth in a session. If you are fuzzy on what this course is, your students will be fuzzier.

This is not therapy.

There is no clinical diagnosis here. No DSM-5. No trauma processing protocols. If a student needs therapy — and some will — your job is to recognize that and point them toward it, not to become their therapist. The moment you start doing amateur therapy, you are in over your head and potentially doing harm. Know the boundary.

This is not a TAP class.

TAP (Transition Assistance Program) is a bureaucratic requirement. It teaches veterans how to write a resume and shake hands in a business setting. MISSION REBUILD™ goes deeper: identity, purpose, financial architecture, relationships, community. TAP tells veterans how to survive the transition. This course is about how to actually build a life worth living on the other side of it. Students who compare this to TAP need to hear that distinction clearly and early.

This is not hustle culture.

Do not pitch this course as a grind-harder, wake-up-at-4am, be-your-best-self program. That messaging is hollow for most veterans and offensive to some. Veterans have already given everything they had on someone else's timeline. This course is not about giving more. It is about building something real, sustainable, and theirs. Drop the hustle language. Use builder language instead.

This is not a pep rally.

You will not be standing in front of a whiteboard drawing lightning bolts and telling people they can do anything. That kind of energy reads as fake to veterans within about 30 seconds. What earns trust in this audience is honesty, specificity, and demonstrated competence. Be those things.

This is not a complaint session.

The transition is legitimately hard. Veterans have real grievances. Civilian life is genuinely disorienting. Acknowledge that. But do not let the course become a space where people come to validate how bad things are and then leave feeling worse. Every session should end with a student knowing what to do next.

What This Course IS**A tactical blueprint from lived experience.**

The frameworks in this course were not developed in a university. They were developed by someone who went through the transition, made expensive mistakes, figured things out, and then refined what worked into something teachable. That lineage matters. Lead with it when you introduce the course.

A structured ramp from military identity to civilian self-authorship.

The military gives structure, purpose, identity, and belonging. Leaving it takes all four at once. This course rebuilds them — not as a replacement for the military, but as something the veteran owns and operates independently. The curriculum moves in that order deliberately.

A peer-to-peer learning environment.

You are not the only expert in the room. Veterans in your cohort have survived things that most people cannot imagine, figured out logistics in impossible conditions, and led teams under pressure. Those skills transfer. Part of your job is helping students recognize and claim what they already know.

A 12-week commitment, not a quick fix.

Set this expectation clearly in Week 1. Transformation doesn't happen in a weekend seminar. This course is designed with pacing for a reason. The modules build on each other. Students who try to binge the

whole thing in two weeks miss the integration that happens between sessions.

How to Hold the Space Without Being a Therapist

Holding space is not therapy. It is the act of being fully present with someone without trying to fix them, rescue them, or redirect them prematurely. In a veteran setting, it looks like this:

- **Listen without agenda.** When a student shares something hard, your first job is to hear it. Not to solve it. Not to relate it back to your own story. Not to jump to the next agenda item. Hear it.
- **Name what you observe, don't interpret.** "That sounds like it was a heavy experience" is holding space. "That sounds like you have unresolved trauma" is amateur diagnosis. Stay in observation, not interpretation.
- **Tolerate silence.** Many veterans process internally before they speak. A pause is not a problem. Fill silence with patience, not chatter.
- **Know when something is above your pay grade.** If a student is describing suicidal ideation, active addiction in crisis, or severe dissociation, that is above the pay grade of this course. Know your referral resources before the course starts (see Section 7).

You are not responsible for fixing anyone's psychology. You are responsible for creating a container that is safe enough for people to do real work. Those are very different jobs.

The Instructor's Role: Peer, Guide, Experienced Operator — Not Counselor

Think of your role as a team leader who has run the route before. You are not the general planning the operation from a map room. You are not the psychologist debriefing the team afterward. You are the sergeant who says: "I've been through this terrain. Here's what I know. Here's what got me through. Here's what I wish I'd done differently. Now let's figure out what works for you."

That framing gives you authority without omniscience. It gives students permission to disagree with you, to have a different experience, to find their own path — while still respecting your guidance.

What this means practically:

- Share your own story when it is relevant and helpful (see Teaching Tips on personal stories)
 - Be honest when you don't know the answer
 - Refer out freely and without embarrassment when something is outside your scope
 - Maintain appropriate professional boundaries — you are not a friend, you are a guide
 - Do not make students' success or failure about your performance as an instructor
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SECTION 2: TEACHING TIPS

How to Use the Operator Tone Without Being a Drill Sergeant

The operator tone is direct, clear, and action-oriented. It does not waste words. It does not soften hard truths into oblivion. Veterans respond to it because it is the register they've spent years communicating in.

But there is a difference between an operator tone and a drill sergeant tone.

Operator tone: "Here's the situation, here's what we need to do, here's why it matters. You have the information. Execute."

Drill sergeant tone: "You are not moving fast enough. Get it together. There is no excuse for this."

The drill sergeant tone weaponizes pressure. The operator tone uses clarity as a form of respect. In a course setting, the operator tone means:

- Give clear instructions without unnecessary preamble
- Tell students what they are doing and why, not just what
- Be direct when you see someone avoiding the work
- Do not bury feedback in so many qualifiers that it becomes meaningless
- Treat students as capable adults who can handle honest information

What to avoid: using military jargon or rank structure as a way to establish authority. Some students will have higher rank than you. Some will have been in different branches or different cultures within the military. Lead with competence and character, not rank.

When to Push, When to Back Off

Push when:

- A student is intellectualizing instead of engaging (talking about the concept but not applying it to themselves)
- A student has been in "figuring it out" mode for multiple sessions without producing any output
- A student is using busyness as an avoidance strategy
- A student is clearly capable but playing small out of fear

Back off when:

- A student just shared something genuinely hard and needs a moment
- A student is in an active external crisis (financial collapse, relationship breakdown, health emergency)

- A student shows signs of emotional flooding (visible distress, shutdown, inability to process)
- A student has already taken the step you were pushing them toward and just needs acknowledgment

The calibration is always: is this person stuck because they are avoiding, or stuck because they need more time, support, or resources? The interventions for those two things are completely different. Pushing someone who is overwhelmed is counterproductive and damages trust.

How to Make Lectures Feel Like Conversations

Veterans tune out lectures. They have sat through enough death-by-PowerPoint briefings to last several lifetimes. The moment your delivery feels like a briefing, you lose them.

Techniques that work:

Open with a question, not a statement. Instead of "Today we're going to talk about identity," open with "Before we get into anything — when you first got out, what was the first moment you felt like you didn't know who you were anymore?" Let two or three people respond before you go into content.

Use the "think about a time when" technique. Before introducing a concept, anchor students in their own experience. "Think about a time when you had a clear mission and a clear team. What made that different from where you are now?" Then connect their answers to the content.

Check for resonance as you go. Don't wait until the end. Every 10-15 minutes, pause and ask: "Is this landing? Who is this connecting for, and who is it not connecting for?" Let students recalibrate the discussion.

Summarize out loud and invite correction. "What I'm hearing from this group is X. Is that accurate?" Giving students the chance to correct your summary keeps them engaged and shows you're actually listening.

Keep lecture segments short. 10-12 minutes of direct instruction maximum before you transition to discussion, application, or reflection. If you need more time for content, break it into pieces.

Using Personal Stories Effectively (Vulnerability Without Oversharing)

Personal stories are your most powerful teaching tool. They also carry the most risk if used poorly.

What makes a personal story effective:

- It is specific (not vague and inspirational)

- It has a clear point that connects to the student's situation
- It ends with what you learned or did, not just what happened to you
- It takes 2-3 minutes, not 15

What makes a personal story land wrong:

- It makes the instructor the hero of every story
- It centers the instructor's struggle rather than the student's learning
- It is so heavy that students feel obligated to take care of you
- It becomes a recurring theme that defines the instructor's identity in the room

The rule of thumb: Share enough that students know you've been through something real. Don't share so much that students start worrying about you, feeling competitive with your story, or feeling like they need to match your level of disclosure.

A template that works: "When I got out, I [specific situation]. I didn't handle it well because [honest self-assessment]. What eventually worked was [specific action or shift]. I'm not saying your situation is the same — but here's what I took from it that might be useful."

How to Handle Cynical or Resistant Veterans

There will be some. Veterans who have been burned by the VA, by the transition process, by employers who said they valued veterans and then didn't, by civilians who thanked them for their service while having no idea what that meant — these veterans have earned some of their cynicism. Treat it with respect, not as a problem to be solved.

What not to do:

- Do not argue with their cynicism. You will lose, and you will damage the relationship.
- Do not overexplain or defend the course. That reads as insecurity.
- Do not try to cheer them out of it. That is condescending.
- Do not single them out or use them as an example of resistance for the group.

What works:

- Name the skepticism directly and validate it. "I would be surprised if there wasn't someone in here who is looking at this and thinking, 'Why would this be any different than the last ten things that didn't work.' That's a reasonable question."
- Let them keep their skepticism and invite them to test the material rather than accept it on faith. "You don't have to believe it. Try it for four weeks and see if it produces anything useful. If it doesn't, you'll have more data."

- Watch for the moment the resistant veteran actually engages with something — because they often become the most vocal advocates once something lands.
 - If a student's cynicism is actively disrupting the cohort (interrupting, undercutting other students' progress), address it privately and directly, not in front of the group.
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How to Engage Veterans Who Aren't Used to Reflection or Emotional Work

Many veterans have spent years operating in environments where emotional processing was not only discouraged but actively penalized. Introspection can feel foreign, soft, or pointless. You will have students who genuinely do not know how to "reflect" because they have never been given permission or structure to do it.

Meet them where they are. Do not start with "How does that make you feel?" Start with "What did you notice?" or "What was the outcome?" Behavioral and observational entry points are more accessible than emotional ones.

Give reflection a tactical frame. After-action reviews are a reflection tool. Debriefs are reflection tools. Intelligence analysis is a reflection tool. Frame exercises as AARs, not therapy homework. "We're running a quick AAR on your transition so far. What went right? What went wrong? What would you do differently?"

Let action lead. Some veterans integrate through doing, not through discussing feelings. Lean into the assignments. Let them complete the work and then discuss what came up in the process of doing it, rather than asking them to reflect before they have material to reflect on.

Make it normal. Self-awareness is a leadership competency. Frame it explicitly that way. "The best leaders I've read about and studied are people who understood what they were good at, what their blind spots were, and how they operated under pressure. That's not soft. That's operational intelligence about yourself."

SECTION 3: COMMON STUDENT CHALLENGES BY MODULE

Module 0: Welcome and Orientation

Common struggle: Skepticism about the course and passive resistance to engaging fully.

Why veterans find it hard: They have been through mandatory training. They have sat through VA programs that didn't deliver. They are protecting themselves from another disappointment.

How to address it: Don't try to sell the course in Module 0. Instead, sell the idea that their attention and effort are worth investing in something — and then demonstrate it immediately by making Module 0 actually useful and respectful of their time.

What NOT to say: "This course is going to change your life." (Overpromising. Reads as sales pitch.)

Module 1: Identity After Service

Common struggle: Inability to articulate who they are outside of their military role.

Why veterans find it hard: Military identity is total identity. Rank, unit, MOS, time in service — these are not just job descriptors, they are the full answer to "who are you?" Losing them is not a career transition. It is an identity amputation.

How to address it: Normalize the disorientation. "Not knowing who you are right now is not a character flaw. It is a completely predictable consequence of leaving a total institution." Then move quickly to exercises that help students locate values, strengths, and stories that exist independent of their service.

What NOT to say: "You're so much more than just a veteran." (Dismisses the depth of what was lost and feels invalidating.)

Module 2: Purpose and Direction

Common struggle: Paralysis from too many options, or overcommitment to a path chosen out of desperation rather than clarity.

Why veterans find it hard: In the military, purpose is assigned. Mission comes from above. Having to generate your own purpose is a genuinely novel cognitive task for many veterans, and it can produce either paralysis (too many choices, none feel right) or false certainty (latching onto the first thing that sounds viable).

How to address it: Help students separate "things I'm interested in" from "things I feel I should pursue" from "things that actually energize me." Do this through structured exercises rather than open-ended reflection. Give them a process, not an empty whiteboard.

What NOT to say: "What is your passion?" (This question paralyzes people who are trained to have a mission assigned, not discovered. It also implies that passion is a thing that simply exists, waiting to be found.)

Module 3: Structure Without the Military

Common struggle: Either rigidly replicating military schedules that don't fit civilian life, or swinging to the opposite extreme and having no structure at all.

Why veterans find it hard: The military provides external structure completely. Time, meals, accountability, consequences — all externally managed. Building internal structure is a skill that was never required before, and many veterans have never developed it.

How to address it: Help students design minimum viable structure — the floor, not the ceiling. "What is the smallest number of anchors in your day that would keep you functional and moving forward?" Then build from there. Do not present an idealized schedule and ask them to fill it in. Start from their current reality.

What NOT to say: "You just need more discipline." (Implies this is a character problem when it is actually a systems problem. Also deeply condescending to people who may have maintained discipline under conditions the speaker cannot imagine.)

Module 4: Financial Foundation

Common struggle: Either shame about their current financial situation, or overconfidence based on BAH/BAS that no longer applies.

Why veterans find it hard: Military compensation is structured in ways that obscure true cost of living (housing allowance, free healthcare, commissary, PX access, etc.). Many veterans genuinely do not know how much they were making in real-world equivalent terms, or how much they are now spending without those subsidies.

How to address it: Start with a financial reality exercise that is practical, not judgmental. "Let's figure out what you're actually working with right now." Do not start with investment strategies or financial goals. Start with current numbers. Then work outward from there.

What NOT to say: "You should have been saving more while you were in." (Useless, backward-looking, and demoralizing. Serves no purpose.)

Module 5: Employment and Career Strategy

Common struggle: Translating military experience into civilian language, or undervaluing their experience in civilian job markets.

Why veterans find it hard: Military accomplishments are described in military language that civilian hiring managers often cannot parse. Many veterans undersell because they were trained not to self-promote, or oversell in ways that don't translate because they emphasize scale and authority rather than outcomes and impact.

How to address it: Do concrete translation exercises. Take specific military accomplishments and rewrite them in civilian outcome language. Practice with real examples from the student's service record. Role-play interviews. Do not lecture about "soft skills" without practical application.

What NOT to say: "Civilians don't understand what you did, so you have to dumb it down." (Insulting to the veteran and inaccurate — civilian hiring managers can understand impact, they just can't decode military jargon.)

Module 6: Relationships and Communication

Common struggle: Communication styles that worked in a military hierarchy don't translate well to civilian partnerships, friendships, or workplaces.

Why veterans find it hard: Military communication is directive, hierarchical, and often terse. Civilian relationships — especially intimate ones — require more explicit emotional expression, negotiation, and non-hierarchical communication. The gap between these modes can cause real damage at home before the veteran realizes the problem.

How to address it: Frame this as a communication mode shift rather than a personality problem. "You have one set of communication tools. Civilian life requires a different set. You can learn the new tools without abandoning what works."

What NOT to say: "You just need to be more open." (Vague to the point of uselessness, and feels like a criticism rather than guidance.)

Module 7: Community and Belonging

Common struggle: Profound loneliness and an inability to replicate the depth of connection that military service provided.

Why veterans find it hard: The bonds formed in military service — particularly in combat units or deployed environments — are among the deepest human connections possible. Civilian friendships feel shallow by comparison, not because they are inherently less valuable, but because they have not been forged under the same conditions. Veterans often conclude that meaningful connection is only possible through service.

How to address it: Help students understand the conditions that created depth in military relationships (shared purpose, shared hardship, interdependence, proximity, time) and then identify which of those conditions can be replicated or approximated in civilian life. The goal is not to find a replacement for your unit — it is to understand what you were actually hungry for and find ways to nourish it.

What NOT to say: "You'll make new friends." (Minimizes the depth of the loss and is not helpful.)

Module 8: Health and Resilience

Common struggle: Either ignoring physical and mental health needs entirely, or becoming consumed by medical documentation and VA claims.

Why veterans find it hard: Military culture often treats health problems as weakness, creating a pattern of suppression that many veterans carry into civilian life. Simultaneously, the VA claims process incentivizes focusing on disability and limitation in ways that can be psychologically counterproductive.

How to address it: Help students separate two conversations: (1) What health support do I need and how do I access it? and (2) How do I build a lifestyle that supports my physical and mental resilience going forward? Both conversations matter. Neither should crowd out the other.

What NOT to say: "Have you tried yoga?" or any advice that trivializes legitimate health challenges.

Module 9: Entrepreneurship and Side Income

Common struggle: Either impulsive business launch without adequate planning, or paralysis from perfectionism.

Why veterans find it hard: Veterans are capable of extraordinary execution but may lack business fundamentals. The combination of high competence in action and low experience in commercial contexts can lead to confident mistakes or, conversely, an inability to start because they don't yet know what they don't know.

How to address it: The goal of this module is not to turn everyone into an entrepreneur. It is to open the aperture on income possibilities and give students a realistic framework for evaluating options. Distinguish clearly between "starting a business" and "generating additional income." Not everyone should start a business, and that should be said plainly.

What NOT to say: "Veterans are natural entrepreneurs." (This is a stereotype that can lead veterans to pursue entrepreneurship when it is not the right path for them.)

Module 10: Long-Term Vision and Goal Architecture

Common struggle: Either vague, un motivating goals or highly specific goals with no bridge to current action.

Why veterans find it hard: Military goal-setting is done within a clear operational framework. Civilian goal-setting happens in a much more ambiguous environment with fewer checkpoints and no external accountability structure. Many veterans find the civilian approach to goal-setting either too soft (vision boards) or too abstract (five-year plans).

How to address it: Use backward planning — the military planning method — applied to civilian goals. Start with the desired end state, identify intermediate milestones, work backward to current actions. Frame this in terms students already understand.

What NOT to say: "Dream big." (Unhelpfully vague and reads as motivational poster language.)

Module 11: Integration and Next Steps

Common struggle: Difficulty transitioning from course participant to independent operator.

Why veterans find it hard: The structure of the course has provided the external framework that the military used to provide. Ending the course feels like another version of ETS — another loss of structure, community, and accountability.

How to address it: This module should explicitly address this dynamic. Help students identify the structures, communities, and accountability systems they will carry forward after the course ends. The goal of Module 11 is not closure — it is launch.

What NOT to say: "You've got everything you need now." (No they don't. Nobody does. Growth doesn't stop here.)

SECTION 4: SUGGESTED RESPONSES

"I don't need this therapy stuff" Pushback

This will come up. It is usually a combination of genuine discomfort with introspection, cultural conditioning against "soft" content, and self-protection. Treat it as information, not as a problem.

Response framework:

"You're right that this isn't therapy. Therapy is clinical mental health work with a licensed professional. That's not what this is. What this is: a structured process for figuring out who you are now that you're out, what you want to build, and how to build it. That's operational work. Some of it involves looking at how you think about things, because how you think shapes what you do. If that part isn't useful to you, skip it and focus on the parts that are. But I'd ask you to stay in the room and see what lands before you write it off."

What to avoid: Being defensive, over-explaining the distinction, or trying to convince them that their discomfort is actually good for them.

Students Who Are in Crisis

If a student presents with active crisis — expressing suicidal ideation, describing an immediate safety concern, disclosing acute mental health symptoms — your response has two parts: acknowledge, and refer.

Acknowledge first. Do not immediately jump to resources. Say: "I hear you. That sounds incredibly hard. I'm glad you told me."

Then refer clearly and directly. "This is important enough that I want to make sure you get the right support. I'm not the right person to help with this part — but I can connect you with someone who is." Have your resources ready: Veterans Crisis Line (988, then press 1), local VA mental health services, and any program-specific support resources.

Do not abandon. Referring does not mean ending the relationship. Follow up. Check in. Keep showing up as a course instructor while ensuring they have clinical support.

Do not promise confidentiality you cannot keep. If someone's safety is at risk, your obligation is to their safety, not to confidentiality of disclosure.

Students Stuck in Victim Mentality

First, distinguish between legitimate grievance and victim mentality. Many veterans have real grievances — against the VA, against employers who said the right things and then failed them, against a system that prepared them to fight and didn't prepare them to come home. Honoring that is important. Victim mentality is different: it is the ongoing belief that external forces are entirely responsible for one's situation, with no acknowledgment of any internal agency.

When you see it, name it — gently and directly. "I want to reflect something back to you. When I hear you talk about your situation, I notice that everything that is hard lands on what other people did or didn't do. I'm not saying those things aren't real. But I am curious — where do you see yourself having any control here? Even a small amount."

Don't shame it. Victim mentality in veterans often comes from real powerlessness — experiences of genuine helplessness during service or transition. Shaming it entrenches it. Curiosity and gentle challenge work better.

Hold the tension. You can acknowledge that something genuinely unfair happened while also asking what the student intends to do about it. "That was wrong. And it's over. What do you want to do now?"

High-Achievers Who Rush Through Without Integrating

These students complete every assignment fast, score high on assessments, and present as succeeding in the course — but they are executing the work, not doing it. They are pattern-matching to "what a good student does" without genuine engagement.

What to watch for: Responses that are polished but impersonal. Assignments that answer every question correctly but feel generic. Participation that is technically present but emotionally distant.

How to address it: In coaching sessions, slow down and go deeper on one thing. "You've covered a lot. I want to go back to something. You wrote X. What's under that?" Follow the thread to somewhere real.

Name the pattern if needed: "You've been executing this course really well. I want to push you on something. Is any of this actually landing? Because I'm seeing a lot of throughput but I'm not sure how much is sticking."

Students Dealing with Active Relationship or Financial Crises

Some students will be going through divorce, separation, financial emergencies, or family crises while doing the course. The course may feel irrelevant compared to the immediate fire they're managing.

Acknowledge the hierarchy. "If the house is on fire, you put out the fire. Some of what we're working on in the course can actually help with what you're managing right now, but some of it may need to wait. Let's figure out which is which."

Help them triage. Which modules and assignments are most directly relevant to their current situation? Which can be set aside temporarily? Give them a modified plan if needed.

Know when to suggest a break. If a student genuinely cannot engage due to crisis circumstances, it may be better to pause their participation and re-engage when the acute situation has stabilized. This is not failure — it is triage.

Students Who Open Up About Addiction or Substance Use

This will happen. Veterans have higher rates of substance use disorders than the general population, and a course that creates any degree of psychological safety will surface this in some students.

Do not panic. Disclosure is not crisis. A student telling you about their substance use is a sign of trust, not a sign that you need to take immediate action.

Do not judge or lecture. Any response that sounds like disapproval will shut down communication and end the relationship.

Ask about where they are with it. "Thank you for telling me. Are you getting support for this, or is that something you're navigating on your own right now?" This opens a door without demanding disclosure.

Know your resources. VA Substance Use Disorder services, local AA/NA resources, SMART Recovery, and any other relevant support organizations. Have them available. Offer them without pressure.

Maintain appropriate scope. You can acknowledge what they shared, offer resources, and continue supporting them as a course instructor. You are not their substance use counselor.

SECTION 5: PACING GUIDE

Weekly Schedule Overview

Week	Module	Theme	Delivery Mode
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1	0–1	Orientation + Identity	Live cohort call + async
2	2	Purpose and Direction	Live cohort call + async
3	3	Structure Without the Military	Live cohort call + async
4	4	Financial Foundation	Live cohort call + async
5	5	Employment and Career Strategy	Live cohort call + async
6	Mid-Course	Review + Project	Live project review call

7	6	Relationships and Communication	Live cohort call + async
8	7	Community and Belonging	Live cohort call + async
9	8	Health and Resilience	Live cohort call + async
10	9	Entrepreneurship and Side Income	Live cohort call + async
11	10	Long-Term Vision	Live cohort call + async
12	11	Integration and Launch	Live graduation call

Recommended Time Per Module

Live cohort call: 75–90 minutes per session.

- 10 min: Check-in / what's been happening since last week
- 15 min: Module debrief (what landed, what didn't)
- 30–40 min: Core facilitated discussion or activity
- 10–15 min: Assignment preview and questions
- 5 min: Close + commitment round ("What are you doing before next week?")

Self-paced: Students should plan 3–5 hours per module, including video content, readings, and assignments.

When to Slow Down vs. When to Push Forward

Slow down when:

- Multiple students are struggling with the same concept (signals a teaching or framing problem, not just a student problem)
- A critical discussion is unfolding and cutting it short would do more damage than running long
- Students are showing signs of overwhelm — check-in questions come back flat, engagement drops, assignments are getting shorter rather than longer
- A student discloses something significant that the group needs to sit with

Push forward when:

- The group is retreading familiar ground and using discussion as procrastination
- You have reached the end of what this group can get from this particular conversation
- The next module's content will unlock what this group is currently stuck on

- Students have been complaining about the same thing for two sessions and no new information is being added
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Suggested Check-In Points (1-on-1 Touchpoints)

Week 1 (post-orientation): Brief 20-minute onboarding call with each student. Goals: establish rapport, identify any immediate concerns, set expectations.

Week 3: Quick 15-minute pulse check. Goals: catch anyone who is falling behind before the pattern is established, identify anyone who is going through something significant.

Week 6 (mid-course): 30-minute mid-course review. Goals: assess progress on mid-course project, discuss what is and isn't working for the student, recalibrate as needed.

Week 9: Check-in on second half engagement. Goals: catch anyone whose motivation is flagging, identify anyone who has had a significant life change.

Week 12 (graduation): 20-minute close call. Goals: celebrate completion, discuss next steps, gather feedback.

How to Run the Mid-Course Project Review

The mid-course project (assigned in Week 4, reviewed in Week 6) is the first major integration point. Students are asked to produce a document that brings together work from Modules 1–4: a personal identity statement, a clarified purpose direction, a structural framework for their week, and a financial baseline.

Before the review call:

- Read all submitted projects before the call
- Note specific things you want to affirm and specific things you want to challenge
- Flag anyone whose submission suggests they are significantly off track

During the group review call:

- Do not read projects aloud or call people out publicly unless a student volunteers to share
- Use what you read to inform the discussion: "A few things came up across your projects that I want to address..."
- Create space for students to share what surprised them in the process of writing it
- Address common themes, not individual submissions

After the review call:

- Provide written feedback on each project within 5 business days
 - For students who are significantly off track, follow up with a 1-on-1 call
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SECTION 6: DISCUSSION FACILITATION

How to Run a Cohort Call (Structure, Timing, Flow)

Open strong. The first 5 minutes set the tone for the entire session. Do not spend them doing logistics or technical troubleshooting. Have logistics handled before the call starts. Open with a question or a brief framing statement that immediately signals: this will not be a waste of your time.

A reliable opening sequence:

1. Brief warm acknowledgment (1–2 sentences, not a lengthy preamble)
2. Check-in question — something specific and relevant to the week's content
3. 3–4 people respond before you move on
4. Transition directly into the session content

Managing time:

- Track the clock actively. Veterans appreciate when an instructor respects the stated end time.
- If a discussion is going long and is genuinely productive, name it and ask for consent: "We're running over. Is everyone able to stay another 10 minutes, or should I bring this to a close?"
- Never let a cohort call drift past 90 minutes without explicit consent.

Closing strong:

End every call with a commitment round. Go around (or use chat) and have each student state one specific thing they are committing to before the next session. This is not a motivational exercise — it is an accountability structure.

How to Facilitate Peer Discussion Without It Becoming a Complaint Session

Complaint sessions happen when there is no purpose to the conversation other than sharing grievances. Give every discussion a destination.

Before any open discussion, set the frame: "We have 20 minutes. The question I want us to dig into is X. By the end, I want each of us to have Y." When the conversation starts drifting toward venting without

output, redirect: "That's a real and legitimate frustration. I want to hold that and ask: given that, what do you actually do?"

Validate the frustration. Route it toward agency. "Yes, the VA is slow. Yes, civilian employers don't always get it. And — given all of that — what is the move?" This is not toxic positivity. It is maintaining the course's commitment to actionable outcomes.

If a student is clearly using group discussion to vent rather than engage, speak to them privately after the call, not in the group.

How to Encourage Veterans to Give Each Other Direct Feedback

Veterans can give extraordinarily clear, direct, useful feedback — they do it in AARs all the time. The barrier in a group setting is often uncertainty about permission. They don't know if civilian-style "feedback" means the polite corporate version or something more honest.

Give explicit permission for directness: "In this group, when someone asks for feedback, they mean real feedback. Not harsh. But direct. If you see something someone is missing, say it. They're adults. They can handle it."

Use structured peer feedback formats that make directness easier:

- "What's working in what you're describing?"
- "What's the gap you see?"
- "What would you do if this were your situation?"

Model directness yourself. When you give feedback, be specific and clear. That gives permission for students to do the same.

How to Handle Silence in Group Settings

Veterans often don't volunteer in group settings, particularly at the start of a course before trust is established. This is not disengagement. It is caution.

Normalize the silence. Don't rush to fill it with your own voice. Count to ten silently before you speak. Silence that feels awkward to you may feel thoughtful to the group.

Use targeted invitations, not open calls. Instead of "Does anyone want to share?" — which puts the full burden on the individual — try: "I'd like to hear from someone who hasn't spoken yet today. You don't have to have a complete thought — just what's coming up for you." Or: "I want to hear from someone who's been chewing on this since last week."

Use chat as a bridge. In video calls, ask students to type their response in chat before anyone speaks. This gives everyone a chance to formulate a response before the extroverts take over, and it gives you material to work with if verbal responses are slow.

Over time, silence decreases. Don't pathologize early silence. Focus on building the conditions for trust, and participation will follow.

How to Build Psychological Safety in a Veteran Group

Psychological safety in a veteran group looks different than in a corporate team-building context. Veterans are not looking for validation and praise. They are looking for respect, honesty, and competence.

Things that build safety with veterans:

- Following through on what you say you'll do
- Treating them as capable, intelligent adults
- Acknowledging when something in the course is hard without trying to fix it immediately
- Maintaining confidentiality consistently and visibly
- Not performing emotions you don't actually feel
- Being willing to say "I don't know" or "I got that wrong"

Things that undermine safety:

- Inconsistency between what you say and what you do
- Overpraising everything (they will stop trusting your feedback)
- Treating the group as more fragile than they are
- Sharing information disclosed in 1-on-1 settings with the group
- Being defensive when challenged

Safety is earned over weeks, not established in a single session. Be patient. Be consistent. Be honest. That is the formula.

SECTION 7: TRAUMA-AWARE GUIDANCE (NON-CLINICAL)

Recognizing When a Student May Need Professional Support

You are not diagnosing anyone. But you should be able to recognize signs that a student's needs exceed what this course can provide.

Signs to watch for:

- Persistent inability to complete work despite capacity and time (often indicates depression or avoidance related to unprocessed trauma)
- Significant escalation in emotional intensity across sessions
- Disclosure of traumatic events in ways that suggest they are still actively living in them rather than reflecting on them
- Expressions of hopelessness that go beyond frustration with the transition
- Explicit statements about not wanting to be alive or not seeing a future
- Significant functional impairment — inability to manage basic daily tasks
- Substance use that is escalating or interfering with daily function

None of these automatically mean crisis. But all of them warrant a 1-on-1 conversation and a clear, warm referral.

How to Acknowledge Hard Content Without Making It Heavier

When a student shares something genuinely difficult, your acknowledgment should not add emotional weight — it should ground them.

What grounding acknowledgment sounds like:

- "That's significant. I'm glad you said it."
- "That took something to share. Thank you."
- "I hear you. That's real."

What adds weight (avoid):

- "Oh my God, that's awful." (Your distress is now their problem.)
- "I can't imagine what that must have been like." (Puts the focus on your imagination, not their experience.)
- "That makes so much sense — with everything you've been through..." (Begins to create a story about them based on limited information.)

After acknowledgment, ground in the present: "You've told me something important about where you've been. What do you need right now, in this moment, to be able to keep going today?"

Language to Use and Avoid Around Mental Health Topics

Use:

- "Mental health" (normalized, non-clinical)
- "Getting support"
- "Talking to someone"
- "Taking care of your mental health" (same framing as physical health)
- "Professional support" or "clinical support" when referring to therapy

Avoid:

- "Crazy" or "insane" as casual descriptors
- "Broken" — this framing causes harm
- "PTSD" as a casual descriptor for any stress response
- "Trauma" to describe every hard experience (dilutes the term and can be invalidating to those with genuine trauma histories)
- "You should see a therapist" as a way to close a conversation you're uncomfortable with

When mental health referrals are necessary, make them warmly and specifically: "There's a resource I want to share with you — the Veterans Crisis Line has counselors available 24/7, and the VA mental health services in your area can connect you with longer-term support. I'm happy to help you find the right contact if that would be useful."

The Difference Between Trauma-Aware Facilitation and Therapy

Trauma-aware facilitation means:

- You understand that some course participants have histories that include traumatic experiences
- You structure content and discussion in ways that do not unnecessarily re-expose people to triggers without support
- You do not demand emotional disclosure as a condition of participation
- You create genuine choice and agency in how people engage with difficult content
- You know how to recognize when someone needs clinical support and you know how to refer

Trauma-aware facilitation is NOT:

- Treating every veteran as if they are fragile
- Avoiding all difficult content because it might be hard
- Processing traumatic material with students
- Doing somatic work, EMDR, parts work, or any other clinical intervention

The line is this: you can acknowledge that difficult experiences exist and shape how people show up in the room. You cannot and should not try to help people process, heal, or integrate those experiences. That is

clinical work. Leave it to clinicians.

When and How to Refer to VA Mental Health Services

When: Any time a student describes symptoms or functioning that suggests they need clinical support. This includes expressions of suicidality, significant depression or anxiety, active substance use disorders, descriptions of intrusive symptoms or flashbacks, or any indication that their mental health is interfering with their ability to function.

How: Warmly, specifically, and without making it the end of your relationship with them.

"I want to make sure you have access to the best support for this. What you're describing is really something that a mental health professional can help with more than I can in this context. The VA offers mental health services — if you haven't connected with them, that might be a really valuable step. Can I share some information with you?"

Key resources to have ready:

- Veterans Crisis Line: 988, then press 1 (also text 838255, or chat at VeteransCrisisLine.net)
- VA Mental Health Services: va.gov/mental-health
- Make the Connection: maketheconnection.net (veteran-focused mental health resource)
- Local Vet Center locations: va.gov/find-locations (Vet Centers often have shorter wait times than main VA)

Do not make referrals feel like dismissal. "I'm still here as your instructor. I also want you to have this additional support."

SECTION 8: KEEPING THE COURSE PRACTICAL

How to Prevent the Course From Becoming a Feelings Festival

The course has emotional content. That is intentional and appropriate. But an over-emphasis on emotional processing at the expense of concrete action defeats the purpose of the course and loses the audience.

The anchor: Every module has assignments. Every assignment produces an output. That output is the anchor. No matter how rich or difficult the discussion gets, come back to the output.

At the start of every session: "By the end of this week's work, you will have [specific deliverable]." At the end of every session: "Before next week, your job is to [specific action]."

Keep discussion time balanced with application time. If you spend 60 minutes in powerful discussion and no one knows what they're supposed to do with what they just learned, you've done emotional experience without integration.

Assignments as Anchors

Every assignment in this course is designed to produce something tangible: a written document, a decision, a conversation, a framework, a plan. These are not journaling prompts. They are operations.

Frame assignments as outputs, not exercises. Not "journal about your values" but "produce a written values statement you could share with someone who doesn't know you." Not "reflect on your transition" but "write an after-action review of your first year out."

When students push back on assignments ("Why do I need to write this down?"), the answer is: because thinking about something and writing it down are different cognitive processes. Writing forces specificity. Specificity creates clarity. Clarity enables action.

The "So What, Now What" Framework for Every Discussion

Apply this at the close of every significant discussion:

So what: "What does this mean? What is the takeaway here?"

Now what: "Given that, what do you actually do? What is the next concrete action?"

This prevents discussions from ending in the abstract. It also trains students to connect insight to action — a habit that persists beyond the course.

You can teach students this framework explicitly so they can apply it to their own thinking between sessions. "When you catch yourself having an insight but not knowing what to do with it, run it through 'so what, now what.' It usually unsticks things."

How to Make Reflection Exercises Feel Tactical, Not Touchy-Feely

Language matters enormously here. The content of a reflection exercise can be identical, but the framing determines whether veterans engage or check out.

Reframe the language:

| Avoid | Use instead |

|-----|-----|

| "Reflect on your feelings about..." | "Run an AAR on..." |

| "Journal about your emotional experience of..." | "Write an honest assessment of..." |

| "Explore what this brings up for you" | "Identify what this situation is telling you" |

| "Get in touch with your values" | "Define your operating principles" |

| "Sit with this question" | "Work this problem" |

| "What does your gut say?" | "What does your assessment of the situation tell you?" |

The underlying cognitive and emotional work is the same. The frame is different. Veterans who would shut down at "journal about your feelings" will engage fully with "write an honest AAR of the last six months." Use the language that opens the door.

Make the connection to performance explicit. "Self-awareness is not about feelings. It is about operational intelligence. Leaders who know how they function under pressure, what their decision-making patterns are, and what environments bring out their best — those leaders make better decisions than leaders who don't. That's what this work is for."

End of Instructor Guide — MISSION REBUILD™

This document is for instructor use only. Do not distribute to course participants.

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